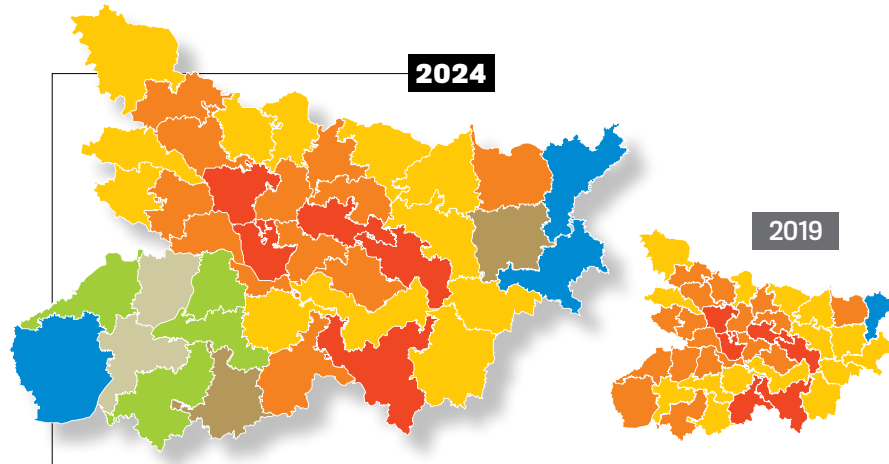


TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 40

	JD(U)	BJP	LJPRV	RJD	INC	CPI(ML) (L)	REST
2024	12 (18.5%)	12 (20.5%)	5 (6.5%)	4 (22.1%)	3 (9.2%)	2 (3%)	2 (20%)
2019	16 (22.3%)	17 (24%)	6 (8%)	0 (15.4%)	1 (7.7%)	0 (1.4%)	0 (21.2%)

Vote share in ( )

Politics may have put them on different planes but fate had Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar and his former deputy Tejaswi Yadav on the same plane on June 5. Or, more specifically the Tata Vistara flight from Patna to Delhi. The young Tejaswi, seated in Row 2, got up to greet the Janata Dal (United) patriarch, hands folded. Nitish enquired about his back, since the toll of holding 251 election rallies had evidently begun telling on the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) scion, seen as he was campaigning in a wheelchair or with a waist belt. Lalu's son assured Nitish that all was well.

The political scars, though, may take longer to heal. Despite a spirited campaign focused on employment and livelihood, Tejaswi proved no match for the combined might of Nitish and the BJP, though his party, along with other partners in the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA)—the Congress and Left parties—did trim the 2019 tally of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) by nine seats.

However, the biggest victory of the 2024 Lok Sabha election in Bihar belonged to Nitish, whose political obituary many a swan song writer had begun drafting. There were whispers about his health, his seeming bursts of temper, intemperate comments and the final straw—his return to the NDA fold this January. Surely, this was the beginning of the end for Nitish, whose status had already diminished considerably with the JD(U) winning just 43 seats in the 2020 assembly election. Rejoining the NDA would leave him on a weaker wicket, it was thought, with the BJP the big brother in the relationship and Nitish forever condemned to the sidelines.

The Bihar chief minister has now broken his silence, not with words but with votes. Yes, his party won four seats less than in 2019—12 out of the 16 it contested, compared to the 16 out of 17 last time. But even the BJP has won the same number out of the 17 it fought. It conceded Buxar, Aurangabad and Patliputra (from where Lalu's daughter Misa Bharti was contesting) to the RJD, Ara and Sasaram to the CPI (ML) (L). It was the Paswan scion Chirag who came good, winning five out of the five seats his party the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) fought, and securing a resounding victory for himself from Hajipur, a seat his late father, former Union minister Ram Vilas Paswan, previously held. Jitan Ram Manjhi kept the lone flag of his Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular) flying from Gaya. Contesting independently Pappu Yadav won in Purnia.

Nitish's 12 seats in the Lok Sabha will ensure that he plays a formidable role within the NDA, second only to Chandrababu Naidu's TDP

As for INDIA, Tejaswi could take heart from the fact that the RJD improved its tally from nil to four and now has a presence in the Lok Sabha. The Congress, too, did two better than its 2019 tally of one seat. With CPI (ML) (L)'s two seats out of the total 40, Bihar was less of a sweep for the NDA.

However, his equal footing with the BJP in Bihar means Nitish is far from a spent political force. His 12 MPs in the Lok Sabha make Nitish a formidable player within the NDA, second only